

Kings Mountain, 1780
The buckskin-clad rebel irregulars found the terrain much more to their liking than their Loyalist opponents, and made excellent use of the cover provided by the hill's wooded slopes.

the frontier fighters delighted in the irritation they caused the British and deliberately cultivated their "wild man" image to psychological effect. Morgan adopted a spine-chilling wild turkey gobble as a signal to his men and they frequently raised an Indian war cry when entering combat.

FRONTIER IRREGULARS

Morgan's riflemen were employed as light infantry skirmishers in Washington's Continental Army. But as the geographical scope of the Revolutionary War expanded into the back country of the South, many more frontiersmen were drawn into the conflict, who fought as irregular bands under self-appointed colonels. They harassed the British and Loyalists, using the classic guerrilla tactics of hit-and-run attacks and ambushes. The raiding of men such as Francis Marion of South Carolina, known as the "swamp fox", were a persistent nuisance to the British, and at times inflicted heavy losses.

The most famous victory by frontier irregulars was won at Kings Mountain in the Carolinas, in October 1780. A force of 1,000 Loyalist militia, led by British officer Colonel Patrick Ferguson – ironically himself a leading advocate of the use of rifles – was surrounded by a somewhat smaller force of rifle-armed backwoodsmen who "opened an irregular but destructive fire". Ferguson mounted bayonet charges to drive the riflemen off, but they simply withdrew, avoiding contact, and resumed their positions once the force of the charge was spent. After suffering more than 300 casualties, including Ferguson and 156 others killed, the entire Loyalist force surrendered.

WORLDWIDE INFLUENCE

Probably the finest hour of the American riflemen came at Cowpens in January 1781, when a mixed force of militia and Continental Army troops commanded by Morgan inflicted a humiliating defeat on the British under Sir Banastre Tarleton. The final British surrender at Yorktown in October 1781 was occasioned by the combined action of the American and French armies and the French navy – a reminder that, whatever their achievements, frontier riflemen could not themselves win a war. But their successes stimulated European armies to increase their use of rifle-armed light infantry and began a shift away from reliance on meticulously drilled formations armed with musket and bayonet.



Fire-lighting kit
A rifleman would be able to light a fire at a moment's notice using tow (hemp or flax fibres) to catch the sparks he struck with his flint and steel. He often carried a pouch of dry kindling as well.

Battlefield of Cowpens
This was the scene of Daniel Morgan's greatest triumph. Skilful use of his sharpshooters caused havoc among the attacking British dragoons; he then ordered a sudden counterattack that led to the surrender of the British force.

